Pakistan began to turn more to China for defence supplies while India started relying more on imports from the Soviet Union. Meanwhile, East Pakistan, which had been left to its own devices, became resentful. Under Mujibur Rahman and the Awami League, it began to agitate for greater autonomy. [123]

Transitions, 1965–1971

The first two decades of Independence were therefore eventful for India on multiple international fronts. India secured territory in the wake of Partition, including through the use of military force. It managed for period to leverage competition between the US and the USSR to derive financial and technological benefits from both. In Asia and Africa, New Delhi assumed an important political leadership role, intervening diplomatically and in some cases militarily to resolve conflicts and shape international outcomes. But from the late 1950s onwards, the Indian economy slowed, the relationship with China deteriorated, differences with Pakistan grew more acute, and the balancing act between the United States and Soviet Union proved both difficult and, in some sense, inadequate.

The disaster of the 1962 Sino–Indian border war had a number of effects. It contributed to the deterioration of Nehru's health and his death in 1964. The India–China relationship saw the suspension of normal diplomatic relations and a military conflagration in Sikkim in 1967, in which India got the better of the People's Liberation Army. In September that year, Indian forces laid barbed wire to prevent clashes between patrols on the border at Nathu La. Chinese forces responded with machine gun fire, after which Indian forces used artillery, causing the PLA to suffer heavy casualties, possibly in the hundreds. Four days later, despite the threat of Chinese escalation, an uneasy ceasefire was brokered. [124]

Other transitions occurred during this period marked primarily by domestic preoccupations. India's cooperation with the United States increased after the 1962 war but military assistance and defence cooperation were suspended with the outbreak of the 1965 India–Pakistan